Your Loudmouth Lesbian Friend

By Marcia Wilkie

Hey there. Hello. It's me, your loudmouth lesbian friend.

In our transient society, with so many parents of young children living long distances from their in-laws or know-it-all aunts, it really has fallen on the shoulders of the lesbian community to step up and be the voice of reason for all our straight sisters who have been hormonally altered through childbirth.

Many have lost that most precious commodity: common sense.

Here I am, the voice of reason. You can count on me.

INTRODUCTION

Are the days of lesbians being viewed with fear and faint disgust by our heterosexual sisters finally at an end? Can lesbians really be a straight girl's best friend?

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We all know about the claim that gay men make great friends for straight women because they love shopping, choosing curtains, and can advise on clothes and makeup.

But perhaps this fascination and focus on sexual preference has gone too far. When will "Your Loudmouth Lesbian Friend" . . . simply become "Your friend?"

This selection by Marcia Wilkie looks at the relationship between straight and lesbian women and especially how that relationship can change when children are factored into the equation.

Your Loudmouth Lesbian Friend by Marcia Wikie.

You called me yesterday, seeking a friendly voice, exhausted from being up all night with your feverish two-year-old.

So, I said: "You know, you're destroying your son's immune system giving him antibiotics."

It's what you need to hear, especially since you've walked the floor for forty-eight hours carrying twenty-four pounds of screaming kid, yanking his ear off his head.

"Listen to me," I said, pleased to have the perfect answer. "Get a pencil and write this down.

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Ready? Give your baby one teaspoon of crushed garlic mixed in a tablespoon of fish oil. That should resolve the infection."

When you tell me that right now your child spits even cherry-flavored Tylenol back out, I think to myself, ***Here's a parent who lacks persistence.*** But what I say out loud to you is "You're the adult. Don't allow that."

Raising children is often just that simple. Isn't it?

Yes. It's me, your loudmouth lesbian friend. Though I have never even read a baby book and I spend less than forty-five minutes a month around anyone under eighteen years old, I know that I can tell you exactly how to parent your child. I can mouth off advice for any age, from babyhood to the bachelor's degree.

For example: When your fifteen-year-old comes home from the school dance with a slight smell of beer on her breath, you can count on me to say something useful, like "Wow. That's a big red flag for future problems."

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Certainly you needed that warning. Somehow, I imagine you saying to your co-parent (if there is one), "You know, our loudmouth lesbian friend might have a point. Perhaps the stocked liquor cabinet we had planned to give our daughter for her Sweet Sixteen isn't such a great idea. And I'm going to return the fake ID we had made for her."

Lucky for you, I'm the loudmouth lesbian friend who is there for you, right from the start.

I show up at the hospital, the day after your C-section, and say comforting things like "Do you think you'll ever regain any muscle tone in your abdomen?" Then I ask to hold your little newbie, bobbling his tiny head around like a Slinky as only a childless lesbian can. Ten minutes later I offer up: "I'd love to stay, but did you know that the florescent lighting in hospitals sucks important nutrients out of the human body? Besides, I'm fighting off a killer sore throat." Before leaving, I lean into the baby's bassinet to give him a smooch.

It's obvious you're being dramatic when you tell me with a shaky voice that you're weary and weepy, you

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love your son, but you're afraid you'll fail as a mom and that you're sore from trying to breast-feed.

"You'll be okay in a day or two," I reassure.

"Really?" a look of hope breaks through your glazed-over expression.

With that, I'm out the door. I can't be late for happy hour at the Closet.

I don't mean to sound self-important, but clearly, I had the solution when you called me for advice. I could hear the desperation in your voice.

"The baby has been upset for weeks," you tell me. "Ten hours a day, and it's making me crazy. My pediatrician said its colic."

I try to speak in calming tones as I tell you that the solution is within reach.

"Get a dab of gel, rub it between your palms, and gently pat it into your baby's hair, until the cowlick lies down. There's no reason to get hysterical over a month of bad hair days."

What would you do without your loudmouth lesbian friend? I'm the one who shows up to your five-

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year-old's birthday party with a bucket of gummi worms, a Super Soaker, and ten cans of Silly String.

The kids have been quietly putting a puzzle together on the floor while the parents chat over coffee and bagels.

I pull you aside. "See, this is why childhood obesity is rampant," I say, pointing to the composed, contented kids.

Two minutes later I have every child running and screeching through your clean house as I make crazy monster noises and chase them with the giant water pistol. It is only after one kid has crashed head-first into a door jamb, corn syrup solids have been drooled across the sofa, and every child is panting and crazed and moments from meltdown that I announce my departure. It's been fun, but I've got a 3:30 massage.

As a tried-and-true loudmouth lesbian, I'm great at pointing out your parenting shortcomings.

You looked so happy on the afternoon you got an hour away without kids to grab lunch with me, until I noticed a clean diaper in your backpack.

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"He's still not potty trained at three and a half?" I shriek, because you just don't have enough shrieking in your life.

"Every child is different," you shrug, going back to your chopped chicken salad.

I, more than many, know that "every child is different." After all, my mother never expected to raise a lesbian daughter who wouldn't give her grandkids. I just was. It was my nature, my spirit, my road to travel, and those things have very little to do with parenting.

But I can't let it be that simple, or that complicated.

So instead, I think to myself, ***This mom lacks initiative***, but what I say out loud is "Well, you better force the issue. Having a Diaper Genie in his dorm room is not going to get him dates in college," With that I secure my loudmouth lesbian title.

How many hundreds of times will I slap my head in regret over voicing my unneeded and inexperienced opinion? I'm amazed that you still want a loudmouth

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lesbian friend around. You wanted your child to now gay people, but I'm sure by now you are wishing you had been more selective.

I know the truth. You don't need a loudmouth lesbian friend telling you how to parent. . .I need you. I need you because I'm not going to be a parent. I need to be around you and your babies, so I can realistically mark the passage of time. Otherwise, I might fool myself into believing that my whole life is ahead of me, because the only change I see is in a mirror. You, however, have the good fortune of seeing through your off-spring that the moment is now. That tie, like a growing child, can never be recovered.

Please don't let me become one of those homos that treat their pets like children. I don't want to build a cat condo for Snowflake. I'd rather build a sandbox for your son. I don't want to spend five bucks on a dog bakery treat for Buster, when he's obviously just as

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happy gobbling up horse turds on a hiking trail It'd rather buy cookies from your little girl's Scout troop.

Don't let me frame photos of golden retrievers and tuxedo cats. I'd rather show off your child's artwork.

It makes me happy if you need me, too. Because I will be the loudmouth lesbian in the bleachers, cheering on your little cheerleader. I'll glow with pride when your son takes honors at the debate tournament. I'll locate the perfect Halloween costume when their request are impossible. I'll try to keep your toddler amused with stories and songs when we are stuck in traffic on the I-10 freeway.

Perhaps I'll be the person you child confides in when she feels different, alone, outside of the group, because she will know that I truly understand what that feels like. Hopefully I'll be the one your high school student calls as midnight when she is in the next city at a forbidden party that has turned dangerous and she is too scared to call you to come get her.

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I will go to get her, no questions asked. I'll drop her off a half block from your house so you don't see my car. I won't drive off until she's safely through your front door. You will never, ever know about it.

See, I don't always have to be your loudmouth lesbian friend. As your friend, I know that what matters to you most is that your child has another reliable adult in her life: one who would rescue her no matter what. You can count on me.

SOURCE INFORMATION

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